

MIG-9

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-9

Age: 39

Gender: Female

Country of origin: Romania

Host country: Italy

Years in host country: 10

Occupation: Home Caregiver

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to Italy ten years ago to work as a live-in caregiver, because opportunities in Romania were scarce and the wages, even for skilled work, were painfully low. A great many Romanian women make this same journey to work in Italian households caring for the elderly, and I followed a path that friends and relatives had taken before me. I left my own children behind in the care of my mother, sending money home every month to support them, which was the whole purpose of the sacrifice. It was, and remains, a painful and complicated choice, to care for other people's elderly relatives while being absent from my own children's daily lives, but it seemed the only way to secure their future and give them chances I never had.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being respected as a skilled worker who provides genuine, demanding care, rather than being dismissed as cheap labour or simply 'the Romanian help,' as though the work I do requires no skill and deserves no recognition. It shows itself when the families I work for treat me as a real part of the household, with dignity and consideration, rather than as invisible hired hands. Belonging, for me, would mean that Italians could see past the negative stereotypes attached to Romanians and recognise the essential care work that so many of us provide, work without which their own system for the elderly would simply collapse. It is a longing to be seen as fully human and genuinely valued.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, Romanians face significant and open xenophobia in Italy, and we are very commonly stereotyped as thieves and criminals, a reputation manufactured by sensationalised coverage of the crimes of a few. I have been treated with visible suspicion in shops, watched as though I were about to steal something, and I have overheard and sometimes been the direct target of cruel comments about my nationality. Some employers exploit our vulnerability, knowing that our immigration and financial situation makes us reluctant to complain or to leave. It is deeply painful to be reduced to a negative and criminal stereotype when in reality I dedicate myself, day and night, to the tender and exhausting work of caring for vulnerable elderly people.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The hardest challenge, without any comparison, was the emotional toll of leaving my own children behind, what people back home sometimes call the 'white orphans,' children raised without their migrant mothers. I found myself raising and caring for other families' elderly relatives while missing every ordinary moment of my own children's growing up, their school events, their small triumphs and troubles. Beyond that grief, learning Italian while working exhausting long hours was draining, and the profound isolation of live-in care work, confined largely to one household with very little free time or social contact of my own, made building any kind of independent life here extraordinarily difficult over the years. The loneliness was at times overwhelming.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: The families I work for vary enormously, and my experience has ranged widely; some have treated me wonderfully, almost like a member of the family, with real warmth and gratitude, while others have been demanding, cold, and quick to find fault. My current employer is genuinely kind and respectful, which has made an immense difference to my daily life and wellbeing. Among the other caregivers, who are mostly Eastern European women in similar situations, there is a strong and sustaining solidarity; we support one another through the loneliness, the difficult employers, and the countless challenges of this particular kind of work, sharing advice and comfort and occasionally just the relief of being understood.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I keep my Romanian identity alive through my Orthodox faith, which is central to who I am and gives me strength, through cooking traditional dishes on my rare days off, and through speaking Romanian with friends here and with my family back home whenever I can. Over the ten years I have also come to genuinely love aspects of Italian culture, the food, the language, the warmth of the people at their best. After a decade I feel authentically connected to both countries, Romanian in my roots and my faith, increasingly Italian in my daily habits, though my heart still aches constantly for my homeland and above all for the children and family I left behind there.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Italian media very often portrays Romanians as criminals, sensationalising the crimes committed by a small minority while completely ignoring the hundreds of thousands of us doing honest, essential, and often invisible work in Italian homes and businesses. This kind of coverage poisons the way ordinary Italians perceive all of us, so that we carry the reputation of the worst regardless of how we actually live. The caregivers, the cleaners, the labourers and workers who quietly support so many Italian families and hold up parts of the economy rarely appear in these stories at all. The imbalance is stark and profoundly unfair, and it directly shapes the suspicion and hostility we face.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: Integration support for economic migrants like me was almost entirely nonexistent, and I learned everything I needed to know through the informal Romanian community here and through simple trial and error, making mistakes and slowly correcting them. Formal language courses were extremely hard to access given the relentless demands of my work schedule, which left almost no free time. Italy relies

very heavily on our labour, on the care work that props up its provision for the elderly, and yet it invests remarkably little in actually helping us to integrate properly into the wider society. We are wanted for our work but largely left to sort out everything else on our own.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children grew up largely without me, which is and always will be my greatest sorrow, the wound at the centre of my whole migration. They are adults now, and I cannot pretend that our relationship was not strained and damaged by all those years of physical separation, by my absence during the times when a mother is most needed. Some Romanian children of migrants do eventually join their parents in Italy and adapt to life here, but many others, like mine, grow up feeling abandoned, however much money was sent and however necessary the sacrifice was. This quiet, generational cost of migration is real and heavy, and it is rarely spoken about honestly.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, Italians genuinely need to recognise just how dependent their society has become on migrant care workers; without us, the entire system for supporting the elderly would quite simply collapse, and this dependence should command respect rather than contempt. The media must stop criminalising entire nationalities on the basis of the actions of a few. And personal relationships within households can and do break down stereotypes powerfully, because many families, having lived closely with a Romanian caregiver, come to love and deeply respect them, discovering the person behind the label. That direct, daily human contact is, in my experience, the most effective cure for prejudice there is.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to eventually return to Romania with enough savings accumulated to live comfortably near my children and, in time, my grandchildren, to try in whatever way I still can to make up for some of the years and closeness that we lost to my long absence. Or perhaps, alternatively, I might one day bring my family to join me here in Italy. But most of all, beyond my own circumstances, I dream of a day when caregiving itself is properly recognised and respected as the skilled, essential, and profoundly valuable profession that it truly is, rather than dismissed as menial work that anyone could do.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to new migrants, and especially to fellow caregivers, is to protect your rights and never to accept exploitation, no matter how desperate or trapped your circumstances make you feel, because there are limits that no employer should be allowed to cross. Learn the language whenever and however you can, even in small snatches of time, because it changes everything about your ability to defend yourself and to belong. Find your community for emotional support, because the loneliness of this work is real and you should not bear it alone. And cherish and maintain your connection to your family back home, because in the end that connection is what sustains you through everything.